BANKING ON PAST SUCCESS, BOLLYWOOD STUDIOS ARE MAKING FOLLOW-UP FEATURES AND ADDING TO FRANCHISES WITH GUSTO. **BUT SUCCESS WITH SEQUELS COMES ONLY WHEN AUDIENCES ARE SERVED THEMATIC FRESHNESS**

By SUHANI SINGH



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Tiger Shroff looks to end his poor box office run with a franchise that elevated him as Bollywood's go-to action hero. The fourth instalment is promising viewers a rebel with "a darker spirit", on "a bloodier mission". Giving Tiger a tough fight will be Sanjay Dutt, who is cast as the antagonist

Vicky Kaushal's fierce turn as Maratha king Sambhaji Maharaj in *Chhaava* has ensured that, like *Pathaan* in 2023, Hindi cinema is off to a soaring start in 2025. With collections of Rs 450 crore in three weeks, the period action drama, which gives a *Gladiator*-like gritty treatment to its warrior hero, has struck a chord. But *Chhava* may just be a handful of original films to succeed in 2025, for the upcoming roster is all about sequels and franchise-building exercises.

Picture this. Ajay Devgn will star in not one, or two, but three sequels: *Son of Sardaar*, *Raid* and *De De Pyaar De*. Akshay Kumar returns for yet another *Housefull*, the second chapter of *Kesari* and *Jolly LLB 3*. Tiger Shroff is banking on the fourth instalment of *Baaghi* to revive his career, while Hrithik Roshan gets into the shoes of a dapper spy for Yash Raj Films' *War 2*. These are just a handful of Hindi films where audiences will revisit familiar characters and themes.

The follow-up trend is here to stay. If YRF and Maddock are betting on the spy and horror comedy universe, respectively, Dharma Productions has another *Dulhania* movie and one more chapter of *Dhadak* and *Kesari*, all releasing in 2025. Apoorva Mehta, Dharma's CEO, doesn't see it as studios 'playing it safe' but more as a means to engage long term with audiences. "Audiences have evolved," he says. "They form strong emotional connections with characters and worlds, and they want to see those stories continue. In a way, sequels allow us to build deeper character arcs, explore new conflicts, and even experiment with different storytelling approaches."



GREENLIGHTING A SEQUEL MAKES ECONOMIC SENSE IF THE FIRST FILM FARED WELL. A PART II CAN BE A PREQUEL TOO, LIKE *KANTARA CHAPTER 1*

Dharma's upcoming films are more an exercise in exploring a theme further by changing the backdrop, time period and even characters. With *Kesari*, it's patriotism, *Dhadak* focuses on prejudice in love, and *Dulhania* continues with good old romance. A sequel, notes Mehta, has to offer something fresh, "whether it's a new perspective, deeper character exploration, or a unique setting", otherwise "it won't resonate, no matter how strong the brand".

Greenlighting a sequel makes economic sense, especially if the first film fared well at the box office. A part II can well be a prequel too—like the Rishab Shetty-starrer *Kantara: Chapter 1*. Filmmaker Vivek Agnihotri, who pushed the concept by building the 'Files trilogy'—*The Tashkent Files*, followed by the blockbuster *The Kashmir Files*. In 2025, he looks to push more buttons with *The Delhi Files–The Bengal Chapter*.

For Shailesh Kapoor, CEO and founder of Ormax Media, a media and entertainment consulting firm, this enthusiastic embracing of sequels/ franchises stems from them replacing stars as the "new trust drivers". "Post-